

Notifiable event procedure

[ORGANISATION NAME] · Version [X.X] · Effective [DATE] · Owner: [ROLE] · Review annually

DRAFT TEMPLATE — not yet reviewed, and not yet your policy. This is general guidance, not legal advice; confirm with your own adviser. Every **highlighted field** must be filled in, and the whole document read and approved by whoever is accountable for health and safety here, before it is issued to anyone or relied on in an emergency.

A notifiable event is the small set of the worst things that can happen at work. When one occurs, three duties start at once: notify the regulator, leave the site alone, and keep the record. This page is the one-pager for the people who have to do that — not a summary of the law. It is deliberately short enough to be read while it is happening.

1. What counts as a notifiable event

Under the Health and Safety at Work Act 2015, a notifiable event is any of three things:

Category	Indicative examples
A death	Any death arising from work.
A notifiable injury or illness	Injuries and illnesses at the serious end, including: amputation; serious head or eye injury; degloving or scalping; spinal injury; loss of a bodily function; serious lacerations; burns or electric shock requiring treatment; and admission to hospital for immediate treatment. Also work-related illnesses and infections of the kinds set out in the Act.
A notifiable incident	An unplanned or uncontrolled incident that <i>exposed anyone</i> to a serious risk to their health or safety — whether or not anybody was actually hurt. For example: escape of a substance, gas or steam; electric shock; a fall or release of plant or an object from height; implosion, explosion or fire; collapse of a structure or an excavation.

These lists are indicative, not the statutory text. Check the current definitions and examples on [worksafe.govt.nz](https://www.worksafe.govt.nz), and have your adviser confirm them for your work, before you rely on this page to decide.

The near-miss trap. A notifiable incident does not require an injury. The test is whether someone was exposed to serious risk. "Nobody got hurt" is not a reason not to notify. If the honest answer is "we're not sure", treat it as notifiable and ring WorkSafe — the duty is to notify, not to be certain.

2. In the first minutes

1. **Make people safe.** First aid, and call 111 if anyone needs emergency services. Nothing in this procedure comes before that.
2. **Make the situation safe** so nobody else is hurt — but do no more to the scene than that (see section 4).
3. Tell **[ROLE — e.g. Site Supervisor]**, who tells the person named in section 3.
4. **Log it in Snag** as a hazard or incident, with photos, while it is fresh.

3. Who notifies WorkSafe

Notifying WorkSafe is the job of	[NAME / ROLE] — [PHONE]
If they cannot be reached	[NAME / ROLE] — [PHONE]

Nobody else notifies

Do not ring the regulator on your own initiative unless both people above are unreachable and the event is a death or a life-threatening injury. Then ring, and tell them afterwards.

WorkSafe notification: 0800 030 040 (24 hours), or notify online at worksafe.govt.nz.

Notify **as soon as possible** after becoming aware that a notifiable event has occurred. If the first notification is made by phone, keep a written record of it, and send written notification as well if asked.

Confirm the current channel and any written follow-up requirement on worksafe.govt.nz — it is the one detail in this document most likely to change.

Have this ready before you call

- Your organisation's name, address and contact details, and the exact location of the event.
- Date and time, and when you became aware of it.
- What happened, in plain words. What the person was doing. What plant or substance was involved.
- Names of anyone injured, the nature of the injuries, and where they were taken.
- What you have done so far to make the site safe.
- The Snag reference number, so the record and the call can be tied together later.

4. Preserving the site — what it actually means

After a notifiable event, the site must be left as it was until a WorkSafe inspector tells you otherwise. In practice: stop work in that area, put up a barrier, and do not tidy up, repair, move plant, or "make it presentable".

You *may* disturb the site to:

- help a casualty, or remove a deceased person;
- make the site safe, or prevent a further event;
- follow a direction from Police or another authority;
- do what is essential to maintain an essential service or utility.

If you have to disturb it, record it. Photograph the scene before and after, note who moved what, when, and why, and put that in the Snag record as evidence. An explained disturbance is defensible; an unexplained one looks like cleaning up.

Who holds the scene here: [ROLE]. **Barrier materials are kept at:** [LOCATION].

5. The next five years

The record of a notifiable event has to be kept for **five years** from the date of notification. That is longer than most people stay in a job, so it cannot depend on anybody's memory or inbox.

Keep	Where
The notification itself, and any WorkSafe reference number, correspondence, or inspector's notice	[LOCATION — e.g. the Snag document library, filed against the snag reference]
The snag record: photos, first-response checklist, witness statements, evidence, root cause or investigation document, corrective actions	Snag — retained against the snag; do not delete it

Any external investigation report, medical or ACC correspondence, and the debrief

[LOCATION]

Reviews. [ROLE] checks open notifiable events at [e.g. each monthly H&S meeting] until every corrective action is verified and the snag is resolved.

6. What Snag does, and what it does not do

Snag does not contact WorkSafe. Reporting an incident in Snag notifies your own organisation's health and safety team by email. It is not a notification to the regulator, and it never has been. The call in section 3 is a separate act by a named person.

What Snag does do is hold the record: the report, the evidence, the investigation and the sign-off, in one place, for as long as you need to produce it. Marking the snag as a notifiable event in Snag records *your decision* — it does not make the notification.

Disclaimer. This template is general guidance prepared as a starting point, not legal advice, and it is not a substitute for reading the Health and Safety at Work Act 2015 and WorkSafe's current guidance. Section references and the categories in section 1 must be verified against the legislation as it stands when you issue this document.

The Health and Safety at Work Amendment Act 2026's ultimate form and survival are contingent on the 7 November 2026 general election and on decisions the next government may make before its 1 April 2027 commencement date. This document should be reviewed by a qualified New Zealand employment / health-and-safety lawyer before it is issued, and revisited once the election outcome and WorkSafe's implementation guidance are known.